Don't Ghost Your Customer

Oct 23, 2026 · @Richa

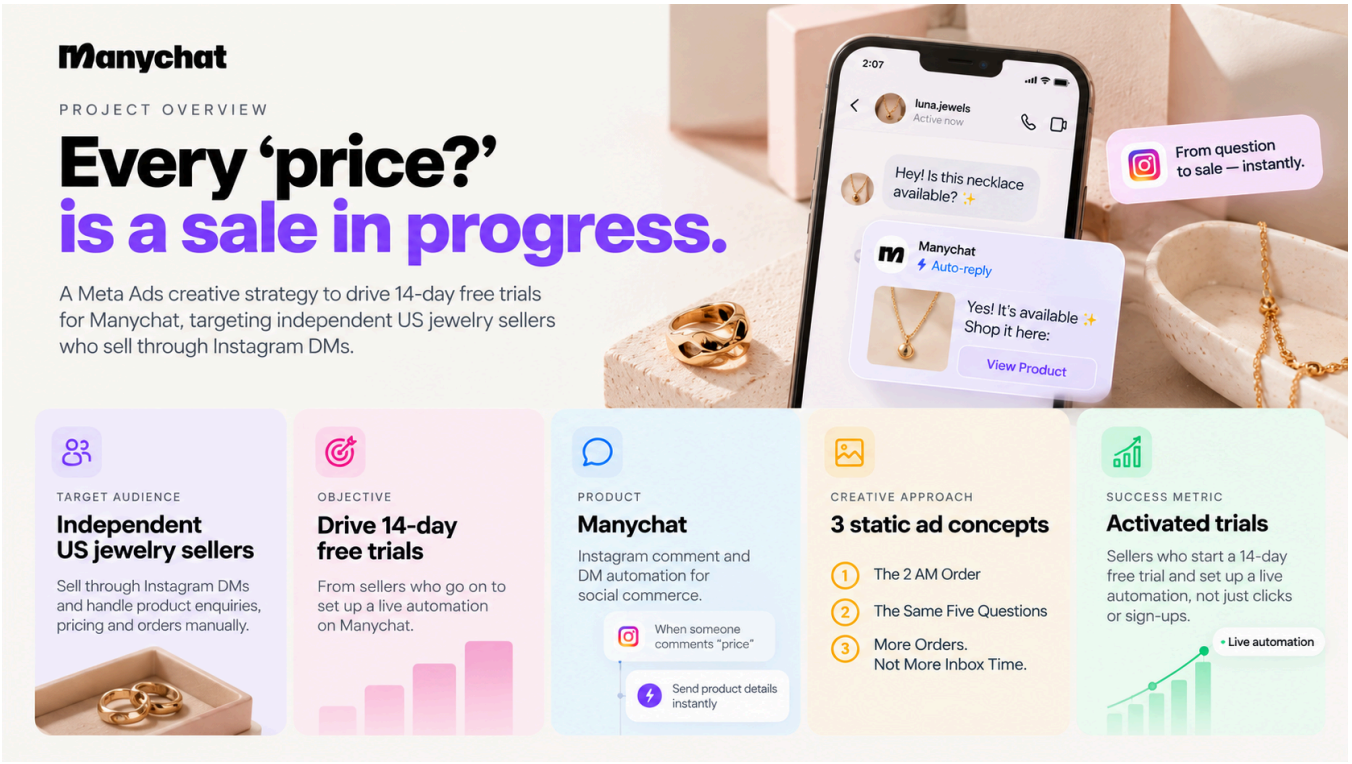
Manychat · Every "price?" is a sale in progress

You have a great product. So what?

Manychat can answer a DM in under a second. So can every challenger in the category, and they all say so.

Here's what I believe nobody is saying out loud: when a buyer waits, the seller doesn't lose time. They lose the sale.

So the campaign is called **Don't Ghost Your Customer**. The idea underneath it: **every "price?" is a sale in progress.** The rest of this case study is how I'd prove it with $3,000, 14 days and three static ads.



Disclosures

Independent concept, not a live project. This campaign wasn't commissioned, approved or run by Manychat. No ads were launched and no budget was spent. I've written it the way I'd pitch it from inside Manychat's growth team; that's a voice, not a claim to work there.

AI and authorship. The research, strategy, core idea and analysis are mine. AI helped me organise my thinking and tighten the writing. It wasn't a source of performance data and didn't verify any ad's results.

Numbers and visuals. Every metric is a speculative benchmark, labelled Hypothesis and pitched a little above the SaaS industry average on Meta. They're the bar I'd set, not results. Ad mockups and the overview card were made with generative AI for presentation only.

Project context

A Meta Ads creative strategy for Manychat, built for independent US jewelry sellers who close sales in their Instagram DMs.

Product	Manychat: Instagram comment and DM automation

Category	Prosumer SaaS for social commerce
Project type	Independent spec campaign; no ads launched, no budget spent
Author and scope	Richa Vyas. Research, strategy, creative concepts, copy, testing plan and measurement
Objective	14-day free trials from sellers who go on to set up a live automation
Evidence labels	**Verified:** sourced. **Observed:** firsthand or public material. **Interpretation:** my reading. **Hypothesis:** to test, including every benchmark

Executive summary

Desire is fast. Replies are slow.

It's 11:48 PM. Someone spots a ring in a Reel, falls a little in love, and DMs: "price?" Then they wait.

While the seller sleeps, Instagram keeps doing its job:

- It shows the buyer five similar rings.
- Another seller, with a lower price and a faster thumb, replies first.
- The buyer starts comparing, second-guessing the value, and wondering if the other shop is more reliable.

The seller wakes up at 9 AM and replies. The buyer has moved on. A customer lost, and nobody will ever know it.

Here's what I believe we keep missing, and I say it as someone who's been the buyer on the other end: "price?", "still available?" and "do you ship?" aren't inbox clutter. **They're buying signals.** Someone wanted the piece enough to ask. But interest has an expiry date, and every minute of waiting hands them another option.

So my brief isn't "get sellers more enquiries". It's "help them convert the ones they're already paying to generate". Here's what I'd want every seller to believe Manychat does for them:

- **Convert more:** turn existing enquiries into buying opportunities.
- **Spend smarter:** get more out of current ad spend instead of buying new leads forever.
- **Save time:** automate the repetitive replies instead of typing each one.
- **Improve returns:** make more sales count without matching manual effort.

How I'd measure it: activated trials and eventual paid conversions, not clicks or cheap signups.

My plan: three creative motivations, one static image ad each, with audience, offer, CTA and landing page held steady. It runs on $3,000 over 14 days. The speculative bar, a little above the industry average: about 100 trial starts, 33 activated trials and roughly $90 per activated trial (Hypothesis). Every outcome stays a hypothesis until the test runs.

Business and product context

We do a lot at Manychat. My call for this campaign is to sell exactly one thing: replying to interested buyers without hand-answering every DM.

How it works

- **Comment-to-DM:** someone comments "RING" or "price" and gets an automated DM.
- **Keyword triggers:** messages like "available?" or "do you ship?" set off automated replies.
- **Shopify integration:** product links connect, and contacts sync with e-commerce tools.
- **Meta integration:** Manychat runs on Instagram's official APIs and says it is an official Meta Business Partner.

In practice: someone comments "RING" on a Reel and gets a DM with the product photo, price, shipping details and a Buy Now button. Less time answering the same questions. More time running the business.

The conversion event: a 14-day free trial

The campaign sends sellers to a paid-plan trial, not a generic free signup.

- **Why not the free plan?** Its contact and automation limits can choke sellers with busy inboxes.
- **Why a paid trial?** It lets sellers feel the product without those ceilings.
- Pricing and trial eligibility get checked against Manychat's current plans before launch.

Why activation matters

From my experience running performance campaigns, a signup is the most flattering and least honest number on a dashboard. The real milestone is the first live automation.

That's why the campaign optimises for activated trials, not cheap signups. We want sellers who use Manychat and have a reason to keep paying. The speculative bar: 45% of trials connect Instagram within 48 hours, and 32% have a live automation within 7 days (Hypothesis).

Product limits to respect

I'd rather under-promise in the ad and over-deliver in the DM, because the fastest way to lose a seller's trust is to promise what we can't do.

Product limitation	Creative implication
Follow-ups need buyer interaction to open a 24-hour window	Don't promise unlimited automated conversations
Non-follower DMs can land in Message Requests	Don't promise every reply is seen immediately
Without Shopify, product details may need manual flow setup	Don't promise an automatically connected catalogue

Problem definition

I don't believe sellers are lazy. I believe desire just moves faster than one person can type.

The moment the problem happens

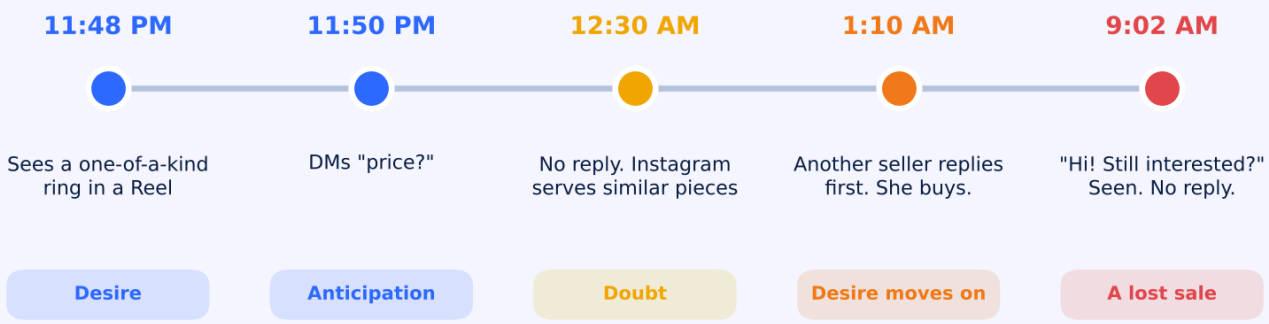
A buyer finds a one-of-a-kind piece in a Reel. There's no price, or they have a question, so they DM. The seller is asleep, at the bench, or wading through 40 other messages. The buyer is still "in the zone", so they keep scrolling, find something similar with less friction, and buy that instead.

Honestly, this case study started with me on the buyer's side (Observed, firsthand). I found unique jewelry on Reels, DMed the seller and waited hours. By the time they replied, the impulse was gone, or I'd already bought a lookalike from a shop with a visible price and a direct link.

The broken buyer journey

The broken buyer journey: what happens between "price?" and the reply

Illustrative scenario · concept visual, not live data



Stage	Today	With Manychat	What the buyer feels
Discovery (11:48 PM)	Sees a one-of-a-kind ring in a Reel	Same	Desire: "I need this"
Question	Comments "price?" or DMs	Gets an instant DM with photo, price, material, shipping time and a "Buy now" button	Anticipation
Waiting	No reply. Keeps scrolling	No waiting	Doubt: "maybe it's sold"
Comparison	Finds a similar piece with a visible price and a checkout link	The original seller's link is already in their DMs	Desire goes to whoever is easiest
Decision	Buys from the competitor	Buys from the original seller while desire peaks	Satisfaction, attached to someone else's brand
9:02 AM	Seller replies "Hi! Still interested?" to silence	The sale already happened; the seller wakes up to an order	Seller: a lost sale they never knew about

The problem statement: an independent jewelry seller's best sales moments happen when they can't reply, and every minute between "price?" and the answer gives desire time to fade or find another seller.

Audience

My bet is on independent US jewelry sellers who sell through Instagram. Their products spark impulse, their buyers compare fast, and the owner is usually the maker too, so nobody is free to reply.

Segments

Segment	Who they are	Why they're prioritised
Primary: independent jewelry sellers	Handmade, vintage and estate, small-batch demi-fine. Solo or two-person shops. Discovery happens on Reels; sales close in DMs, by invoice, or through an Etsy or Shopify link	One-of-a-kind pieces create impulse and FOMO. Buyers comparison-shop. The person who'd reply is busy making the product (Hypothesis, supported by the problem definition)
Secondary (later): small fashion and accessories boutiques	Resale, vintage clothing, small-batch accessories	Same mechanics, bigger pool. Expand once a concept wins with the primary segment

Persona: Maya, 26

A composite built from my research and my read of the category. Details are illustrative, and every figure is a Hypothesis.

Demographics. Maya is 26 and lives in a mid-sized US city, in a rented apartment where the spare room doubles as her studio. She studied fine arts, worked in retail for a few years, and started her handmade jewelry shop as a side hustle three years ago. It now brings in around $60,000 a year, enough that she's quietly planning to drop her part-time job. She runs it alone, with a friend helping pack orders during launches. Her pieces sell for $45 to $180. She has about 18,000 Instagram followers and gets 600 to 900 DMs a month, closer to 2,500 when a Reel takes off or Valentine's Day is near.

Where she sells. Reels for discovery; Shopify or Etsy for checkout; some sales finished by invoice in DMs. Her tool stack is Canva, CapCut, a link-in-bio page and Shopify. No automation yet.

Psychographics. Her pieces are her identity, so a robotic reply feels like a betrayal. She writes "DM for price" because talking money feels awkward. A viral Reel thrills and panics her in equal measure. She'd rather be at the bench than in the inbox, and trusts other makers over any brand.

Behaviour. She batch-films Reels on Sundays and posts three to five a week. She checks DMs late at night and first thing in the morning, replying in bursts rather than in real time. She learns from small-business creators, YouTube tutorials and Etsy-seller groups. She'll happily start a free trial, but abandons anything that takes more than an evening to set up.

Her best moments: a Reel takes off; a new collection drops; US gifting peaks. **Her worst:** waking up to 60 DMs, half of them "price?", and a few that went cold overnight. **What she's tried:** prices in captions, saved replies, Instagram's FAQ settings, "DM for price". **What she believes:** "My customers want to talk to me, not a bot." **What she wants:** more sales from the attention she already gets, without living in her inbox.

Motivations and triggers

- **Fear of loss (Hypothesis).** Finding out a sale went elsewhere stings more than the abstract idea of saving time.
- **Pride in the craft (Hypothesis).** She wants buyers to love the piece, so the reply has to sound like her.
- **Triggers that make the problem visible:** a Reel that overperforms, a launch, holiday gifting peaks, or a buyer saying "never mind, I found one elsewhere".

Objections and how the creative answers them

Objection	How the creative answers it
"Instagram already does this for free."	Its keyword reply waits 15 minutes; ours is instant, with photo, price and link. That proof lives on the landing page, not in the ad
"Bots feel cold. My buyers want me."	Show the DM in her voice, signed with her name
"Will this get my account banned?"	Official Meta Business Partner, near the CTA
"It's too technical."	"One post, one reply", shown in under 3 seconds
"The price goes up as I grow."	The trial is free, and cost grows only with sales conversations. Never lead with price

Awareness level

This audience is problem-aware (they know DMs are slow) but only loosely solution-aware. Comment-to-DM automation is linked with coaches and creators handing out guides, not with selling jewelry (Interpretation). So my rule is simple: the first three seconds of every ad show jewelry, not a generic "business".

Competitive and creative audit

Here's the uncomfortable truth I'd bring to our team: our real rival for this seller isn't another app. It's "good enough": Instagram's free tools plus replying by hand. And the whole category's messaging leaves the buyer's side of the story sitting there, unclaimed.

Competitive landscape

Alternative	What it offers	Where it falls short for Maya
Instagram's free automations	FAQ, instant and keyword replies	Keyword replies wait 15 minutes; no product link per post
Replying by hand	Free and personal	Only works when she's awake
Cheaper challengers (IGMsg, Inrō, SnapDM)	Flat-price comment-to-DM	Compete on price, pushing the category toward commodity
Shopify-focused tools (InstantDM)	Catalogue sync	Attack Manychat on Shopify depth

What this means for the creative: we won't win on price; we win by making slowness hurt and the instant, personal reply obvious.

Creative and messaging audit

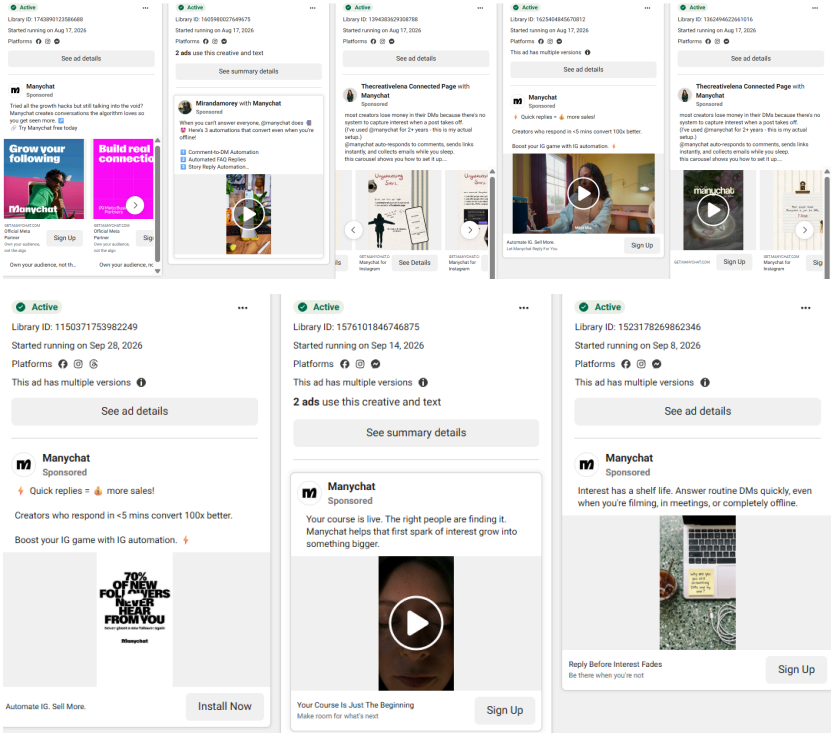
From websites and listings, not ads.

Repeated claim in the category	Example	Gap it leaves
"Every comment is a lead"	IGMsg	Lead language is for marketers. A jewelry maker thinks in pieces and buyers
"Works while you sleep"	IGMsg, Manychat partner content	Says what the tool does, not what it saves
"Safe, official Meta API"	Zapify, Inrō	A defensive claim. Useful near the CTA, weak as a hook
"Save hours, reclaim time"	Inrō	Efficiency is rational. It doesn't create urgency

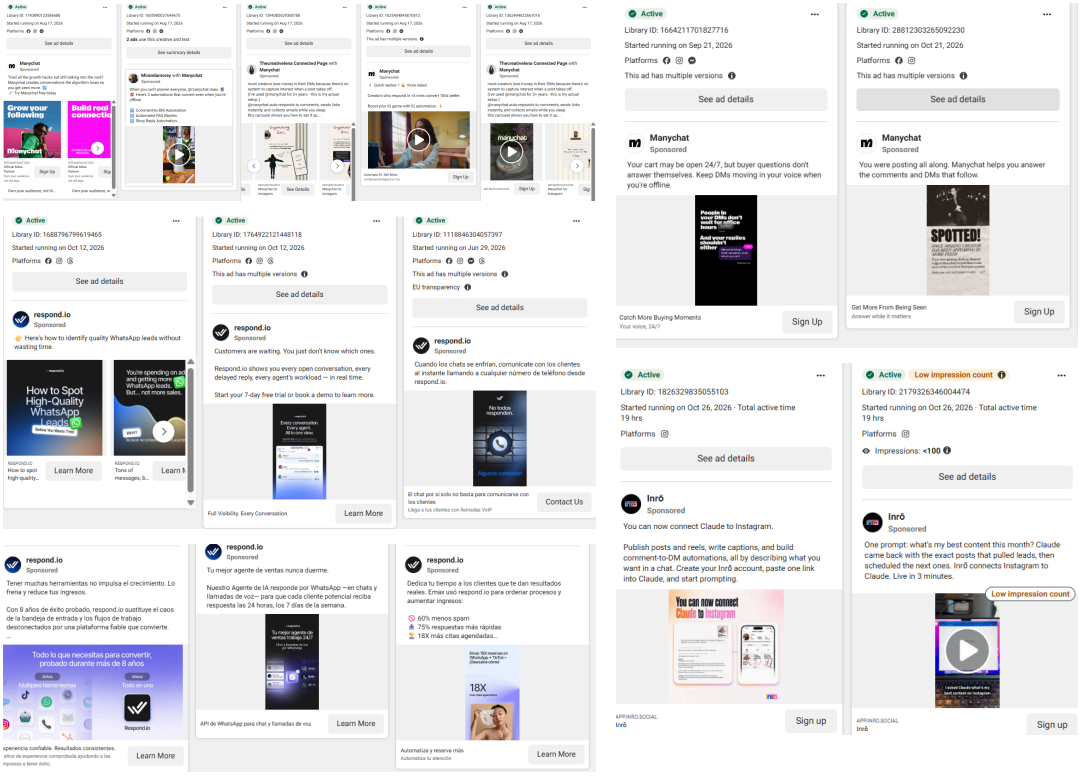
The opening (Interpretation): none of the messaging I reviewed shows the buyer's side, the moment the want fades and the sale walks off. None of it speaks to jewelry or product sellers specifically.

Meta Ad Library snapshots

Manychat



Competition



08 ad library, MC-11 competition 3 (right column)]

Ad Library read: Manychat's creative patterns

A first pass at Manychat's live mix, Aug–Oct 2026. It shows messaging choices, not spend or performance.

Pattern	What I'd do with it
UGC and creator-led video	A later format test, with a visible comment-to-DM demo
Direct-response claims ("Quick replies = more sales", "100x better")	Stand apart with the specific "price?" moment, not broad speed claims
Problem storytelling ("Interest has a shelf life")	Supports our urgency territory; keep the jewelry scene distinctive
Typography statics	Keep static as the comparable format in test one
Many versions, always-on dates	Iterate one variable at a time; never crown a winner on longevity

What this changes. Test one isolates motivation with three statics. Once a concept clears roughly $90 per activated trial, a real-user UGC version can challenge it. Before launch, I'd widen this to a 15 to 20 ad audit.

Strategic synthesis

If I had to fit the whole strategy on a sticky note, it would say this: **sell the seller on the sale they're losing, not the time they'd save, and prove it with how fast the reply lands.**

Key findings and what they mean

Finding	Decision it drives
Buyers' desire fades while they wait, and they drift to easier sellers	Lead with loss and desire, not efficiency
The category talks about leads, sleep and safety	Own the buyer's moment and the product seller
Instagram's free keyword reply waits 15 minutes	Speed is the provable difference
The free plan is too small to prove value	The CTA is the 14-day trial; success means going live
Sellers fear sounding robotic (Hypothesis)	Every DM shown is warm and in the seller's voice

Customer tensions

- "I want to reply personally" versus "I can't be online at 11:48 PM."
- "My pieces are one-of-a-kind" versus "buyers treat me like any other shop when I'm slow."
- "I get plenty of attention" versus "so why don't sales match it?"

Message hierarchy

- **Reframe:** a question like "price?" is a potential buying signal.
- **Stakes:** a slow reply can mean a lost opportunity.
- **Solution:** Manychat can automate Instagram replies with product information and a link.
- **Proof:** a real customer question and the matching automated reply in the static creative.
- **Action:** the approved "Sign Up" CTA, with the destination making the 14-day free trial clear.

Campaign platform

Don't Ghost Your Customer. Every "price?" is a sale in progress.

Element	Definition
Central idea	The questions sellers treat as admin are buyers mid-purchase. Answer them while the desire is alive
Audience promise	Manychat replies the instant they ask, in your voice, with everything they need to buy
Emotional appeal	The sting of a sale you never knew you lost, then relief and pride when it's yours
Functional appeal	Comment or DM, then an instant DM with photo, price and link, then checkout
Tone of voice	Warm, observant, quietly witty. Slice-of-life storytelling in the spirit of Piyush Pandey's work: small human details, no hype, no shouting. The product walks in late and simply
What it is not	A feature list, a "growth hack", a robot mascot, a fake dashboard of revenue numbers

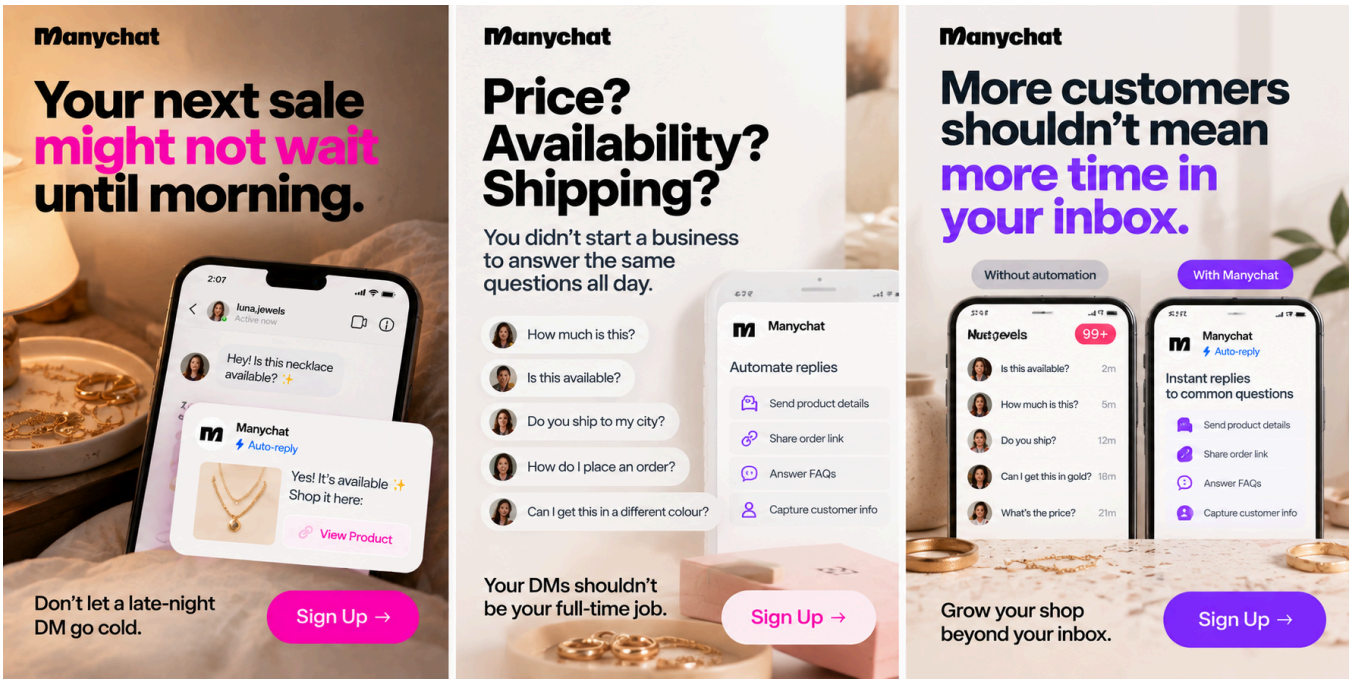
How the platform extends

- **Other questions:** "does it come in silver?", "can you ship by Friday?". Each can be its own ad.
- **US gifting moments:** "He asked the price at 11 PM on Feb 12", plus Mother's Day and holiday versions.
- **Real seller stories:** once trial users go live, their own "the one that got away", with permission.
- **Other segments:** boutiques and resale shops.

Copy guardrails

- Use buyers' real words on screen ("price?", "still available?"), lowercase, exactly as typed.
- Talk about pieces and buyers, not leads and funnels.
- Every product claim on screen must be something Manychat can actually do.

Ad concepts



presentation purposes]

Three static concepts, each built around a different motivation.

The 2 AM Order

Loss aversion · Cold audience → trial

> **ON IMAGE** Your next sale might not wait until morning.
>
> **PRIMARY TEXT** A customer messages your Instagram shop while you're asleep. By morning, the moment to buy may have passed. Manychat helps you automate Instagram replies so customers can get a response even when you're offline.
>
> **HEADLINE** Don't let a late-night DM go cold. **CTA** Sign Up

Why this ad? Small sellers can't answer every DM around the clock. This makes the cost of a delayed reply tangible, and tests whether a sales-loss angle brings in more qualified trials than time-saving or growth.

Visual direction. A late-night DM about availability, a clear cue the seller is offline, and Manychat's reply as supporting proof. The customer message and headline dominate.

The Same Five Questions

Practical problem-solving · Cold audience → trial

> **ON IMAGE** Price? Availability? Shipping? You didn’t start a business to answer the same questions all day.
>
> **PRIMARY TEXT** Price. Availability. Shipping. The same questions, every day. Manychat helps you automate routine Instagram conversations, so you can spend less time repeating answers and more time running your business.
>
> **HEADLINE** Your DMs shouldn’t be your full-time job. **CTA** Sign Up

Why this ad? Repeating the same answers is a familiar, daily burden. This tests whether time lost to repetitive DMs motivates more qualified trials than missed sales or growth.

Visual direction. Typography-led, with repeated questions as Instagram message bubbles. Make the repetition obvious and let automation resolve it. Minimal layout, prominent headline.

More Orders. Not More Inbox Time.

Growth aspiration · Cold audience → trial

> **ON IMAGE** More customers shouldn’t mean more time in your inbox.
>
> **PRIMARY TEXT** As your shop grows, so can the DMs, questions and follow-ups. Manychat helps you automate Instagram conversations and guide customers to the next step, giving you a more manageable way to handle growing demand.
>
> **HEADLINE** Grow your shop beyond your inbox. **CTA** Sign Up

Why this ad? The first two concepts target a pain. This one frames automation as a way to grow, testing whether sellers respond more to handling more conversations without more manual replies.

Visual direction. Before and after: a crowded inbox beside an organised automated flow, with Manychat's interface as proof and the growth headline leading. Never imply automation guarantees sales.

Testing framework

I want the first test to answer one question, and only one: which motivation (loss aversion, practical problem-solving or growth aspiration) brings in jewelry sellers who actually activate a Manychat automation? Each motivation gets one static ad. Format, audience, offer and CTA stay identical, so the only thing on trial is the concept.

Test one: motivation

Element	Setup
What varies	The concept only: The 2 AM Order, The Same Five Questions, and More Orders. Not More Inbox Time.
What stays fixed	Sign Up CTA, 14-day free trial, description line, landing-page template, audience and placements
Assets	One distinct, jewelry-specific static per concept; no video or carousel
Structure	One campaign optimised for trial starts, three ad sets on equal fixed budgets, so Meta can't crown a winner early on cheap clicks
Budget (Hypothesis)	$3,000: $1,000 per concept, about $71 a day each

Element	Setup
Audience	US, broad, with interests like jewelry making, handmade jewelry, Etsy, Shopify and small business; existing customers excluded
Duration	14 days. No winner until each concept reaches 25 trial starts

Decision rules

Outcome	Rule	Next step
Clear winner	Lowest cost per activated trial, ideally under $90, with 25+ trial starts	Scale it; run the hooks test inside it
Clear loser	Highest cost per activated trial and CTR under 1.2%	Pause it; keep its best hook
Split result	One wins attention, another wins activated trials	Activated trials win; try the attention winner's hook on the other's body
Inconclusive	Small gaps, or under 25 trial starts	Extend, or merge the strongest hooks on one body

Roadmap after test one

- **Hooks:** three to five hooks from the winning concept, with the same body and landing page.
- **Visual execution:** controlled static variations of the winner, holding concept and copy steady. A UGC-versus-static test can follow if budget and results justify it.
- **Landing page:** a concept-matched headline against Manychat's generic page, to measure what message match is worth.
- **Then:** scale, and add Valentine's Day, Mother's Day and holiday versions, plus the boutique segment.

Measurement, failure metrics and response framework

North-star metric: cost per activated trial, with a speculative target of about $90 (Hypothesis). An activated trial is a seller who starts the 14-day trial and has a live automation within 7 days. I'd trade a thousand cheap clicks for one seller who goes live.

The metric stack

Stage	Metric	Role
Attention	Impressions, CPM, outbound CTR	Diagnostic
Interest and landing	Cost per click, landing-page view rate, scroll, bounce	Diagnostic
Conversion	Trial-start rate, cost per trial	Primary
Activation	Instagram connected in 48 hours; live automation in 7 days	North star
Revenue and loyalty	Trial-to-paid; 60- and 90-day retention by cohort	Final judge

Failure metrics and response framework

Until Manychat's own baseline exists, I'd judge everything against the speculative benchmarks and the other concepts. If CTR sits under 1.2%, I'd fix the headline and imagery before blaming the idea. If clicks come but trials stay under 6%, the landing page is the suspect, not the ad. Shoppers asking "where's this ring from?" means we're reaching buyers, not sellers. Fewer than 45% connecting Instagram in 48 hours points to onboarding, so I'd nudge with a jewelry template. Trial-to-paid under 25% calls for a day-10 "here's what you sold" message. And if cost per activated trial climbs 25% week on week, that's fatigue: rotate hooks every 2 to 3 weeks.

One rule overrides the rest: a concept with the cheapest trials but the weakest 90-day retention gets its budget capped.

Tracking requirements

- Trial starts via the Meta Pixel and Conversions API, a UTM per concept, and activation sent back server-side so the campaign can later optimise for it. Trial-to-paid and retention live in Manychat's own cohort data. iOS modelling keeps every read directional.

Speculative benchmarks

I'd love to show you real results here, but I can't yet. So I've set the bar I'd hold my own team to. Every number is a Hypothesis pitched a little above the paid-social industry average for SaaS on Meta. The industry column is an approximate reference from general category knowledge, not a sourced figure; both get replaced by Manychat's own baseline once it exists.

Metric	Approx. industry average	Speculative benchmark
CPM (US, broad)	~$19	$17
Outbound CTR	~0.9%	1.2%
Cost per outbound click	~$2.10	$1.42
Landing-page view rate	~75%	80%
Trial-start rate (of page views)	~5%	6%
Cost per trial	~$45	~$30
Instagram connected within 48 hours	~40%	45%
Live automation within 7 days	~28%	32%
Cost per activated trial	~$160	~$90
Trial-to-paid (activated cohort)	~20%	25%

What the $3,000, 14-day test should produce at these benchmarks

Funnel stage	Per concept ($1,000)	Whole test ($3,000)
Impressions	~58,800	~176,500
Outbound clicks	~706	~2,120
Landing-page views	~565	~1,690
Trial starts	~34	~100
Instagram connected (48h)	~15	~46
Activated trials (7 days)	~11	~33
Paid customers	~3	~8

Guardrails

- **My prediction, to be proven wrong:** The 2 AM Order wins CTR and activation; The Same Five Questions brings the cheapest trials; More Orders. Not More Inbox Time. has the lowest CTR but possibly the most loyal cohort.
- These numbers are internal targets only. They never appear in ad creative.

Risks, limitations and next steps

In my view, the biggest risk isn't a weak ad. It's a strong ad that promises more than the product delivers, so every claim stays inside the product's real limits and nothing says "never miss a sale".

The other risks I'd watch: buyer-side stories pulling in shoppers instead of sellers, The Same Five Questions sliding into a generic "save time" message, pricing confusion after the March 2026 plan change, and iOS tracking gaps. A $3,000 test is small, so results stay directional, and the benchmarks may prove optimistic, which is why concepts are judged against each other first. Testimonials come only from real users, with any payment disclosed.

It all rests on a few assumptions I'd validate: that sellers feel lost sales more than lost time, that buyers DM several shops at once, and that Instagram's 15-minute keyword delay still applies at launch.

Next, I'd verify trial terms and features on Manychat's site, widen the Ad Library audit, collect seller verbatims, produce the three statics with matching landing pages, then run test one.

Final recommendation

My recommendation: launch **Don't Ghost Your Customer**, built on "every 'price?' is a sale in progress", as a three-concept static-ad test for independent US jewelry sellers, on $3,000 over 14 days.

- **Lead creative production on The 2 AM Order,** the most distinctive buyer-moment story.
- **Use The Same Five Questions** as the clearest picture of the everyday problem.
- **Use More Orders. Not More Inbox Time.** to test whether growth messaging pulls in stronger prospects.

The category sells time saved. This campaign sells the sale you never knew you lost, and gives it back.

So: three ads, one question, and a bar I've set a little higher than average. That's the honest state of it. The next step is finding out which of my hunches survive contact with a real budget.

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Accessed October 2026. Benchmarks and industry averages are assumptions with no source.

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